

Reality Drift: How Symbolic Systems Lose the Ability to Correct Themselves

A Theory of Representational Misalignment, Operational Continuity, and Weakening Correction

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Abstract

Institutions, technologies, and knowledge systems increasingly remain operational while producing outcomes that are disconnected from the conditions they were created to address. Metrics improve while underlying outcomes deteriorate. Procedures reach completion without resolving the problems that initiated them. Models become more coherent while losing responsiveness to the environments they describe. These failures are difficult to diagnose because they do not initially appear as breakdowns. The system continues to function according to its own internal criteria.

This paper proposes Reality Drift as a theory of representational misalignment in scaled symbolic systems. Reality Drift is the progressive loss of corrective contact between a system's representations and the real-world conditions they are meant to track, describe, or govern, even while the system remains operational and internally coherent. The defining paradox is operational continuity without reliable correction.

The paper introduces the Representation Stack as a reference model for examining how reality is transformed into measurements, metrics, operational representations, optimization targets, and narratives. It then develops the Drift Principle, which holds that representations can be compressed, optimized, distributed, and reused faster than real-world conditions can correct them. Reality Drift becomes self-reinforcing when corrective feedback remains present but loses the authority to revise the representations, objectives, and procedures governing the system.

The framework extends beyond metric distortion. It describes how many forms of representation can acquire operational authority, reorganize the conditions they measure, and interpret those altered conditions as confirmation of their own validity. The paper identifies the mechanisms, boundary conditions, diagnostic implications, and corrective requirements of this process across institutional, technological, and cognitive domains.

1. The Paradox of Operational Continuity

Modern systems increasingly exhibit a form of failure that does not look like failure. Organizations can meet performance targets while becoming less capable of fulfilling their purpose, and models can grow more fluent while becoming less dependable as guides to external conditions. Verification systems may accumulate procedures without becoming better at establishing whether a claim is true. At the individual level, people can process more information, complete more tasks, and satisfy more

procedural demands while becoming less certain that any of it remains connected to meaningful outcomes.

Nothing has to break in the ordinary sense. The machinery of the system can continue working: dashboards update, procedures reach completion, reports remain internally consistent, and models keep producing outputs. The condition does not require deception, incompetence, or corruption. A system can remain functional by its own standards while gradually losing the ability to be corrected by conditions outside them.

This creates a diagnostic problem. Conventional failure analysis looks for visible interruption, inaccurate outputs, missing information, improper incentives, or identifiable misconduct. When the system continues operating, these approaches tend to treat the problem as one of efficiency, implementation, communication, or compliance. The proposed solution is often another representational layer. New metrics are introduced. Reporting requirements expand. Additional models, categories, audits, dashboards, and review procedures are added.

These interventions can increase the system's internal legibility without restoring its contact with the conditions it was created to serve. In some cases, they make the system more coherent while making correction more difficult. Reality Drift names this condition. Reality Drift is the progressive loss of corrective contact between a system's representations and the real-world conditions they are meant to track, describe, or govern, even while the system remains operational and internally coherent.

The defining paradox of Reality Drift is operational continuity without reliable correction. The absence of visible failure does not demonstrate alignment. A system may continue producing valid outputs according to its own rules while becoming progressively less responsive to the reality beyond those rules.

2. Definition and Boundary Conditions

Reality Drift is more than simple inaccuracy. It describes a condition in which misalignment can persist, spread, and become embedded because the system no longer corrects itself effectively. What distinguishes it from ordinary error is not the presence of a bad representation, but the way that representation survives and gains stability within the system. Four conditions are especially important.

2.1 Representational Dependence

The system encounters and acts upon reality primarily through representations. These representations may include measurements, metrics, categories, records, models, procedures, forecasts, narratives, interfaces, benchmarks, or symbolic indicators. Representation makes coordination possible by reducing complex conditions into forms that can be stored, compared, communicated, and acted upon.

Representational dependence is not itself a failure. No complex system can preserve every feature of the reality it encounters. Selection and abstraction are unavoidable. The relevant question is whether the system's representations remain answerable to what they represent.

2.2 Progressive Divergence

The representations guiding the system gradually become less faithful to the conditions they are meant to track. A metric can still be calculated correctly even after it stops describing the outcome that actually matters. Administrative categories can remain stable long after the cases within them have changed, while models built on earlier conditions may continue to appear coherent despite becoming less responsive to the world around them. The divergence often begins quietly, through small exclusions, delayed updates, inherited assumptions, or simplifications that once seemed reasonable. Reality Drift develops when those discrepancies accumulate faster than the system can detect and correct them.

2.3 Correction Weakening

Feedback, verification, constraint, or direct contact becomes unable to repair the divergence. Corrective information can remain present without changing the system. Problems may be recognized, documented, and even formally acknowledged while contradictory evidence continues to accumulate. None of that matters if the information cannot alter what the system is doing.

The decisive issue is corrective authority. Feedback has corrective authority when it can revise the representation or operational proxy, change the objective, interrupt the procedure, or prevent the system from continuing under the same assumptions. When information is collected without the power to produce those changes, it remains informational rather than corrective.

2.4 Operational Persistence

The system continues functioning despite growing misalignment. Procedures are completed, metrics are reported, decisions are made, and outputs remain internally coherent. Because the system has not visibly failed, the divergence can persist without triggering fundamental reconsideration.

Reality Drift emerges when representational dependence, progressive divergence, correction weakening, and operational persistence reinforce one another over time. No single condition is sufficient. The defining pattern is the persistence of representational misalignment without corresponding operational failure.

2.5 What Reality Drift Is Not

Reality Drift is not synonymous with error, bias, misinformation, disagreement, corruption, or deception. Ordinary error may be detected and corrected without changing the structure of the system. Immediate failure interrupts operation and forces a response. Deliberate deception involves knowingly misrepresenting reality. Reality Drift can occur without any participant intending to distort the system.

It is also not equivalent to every established use of the word drift. Data drift, model drift, concept drift, policy drift, and genetic drift have their own domain-specific meanings. These processes may contribute to or resemble Reality Drift, but they are not automatically instances of it.

Reality Drift applies most directly to systems that depend heavily on representations, operate across multiple layers of mediation, optimize measurable outputs, receive delayed or filtered feedback, and can remain functional despite deteriorating real-world outcomes.

3. The Representation Stack

Complex systems rarely act directly upon reality. They act through selected and transformed representations of it.

The Representation Stack provides a reference model for examining these transformations:

Reality → Measurement → Metrics → Operational Representation → Optimization → Narrative

The Stack is not a rigid universal pipeline. Real systems move between these layers recursively, with changes at one level reshaping the others. Institutional narratives can influence what gets measured, while those measurements determine which observations receive attention. Optimization may then alter the environment itself, and the resulting operational representations can become inputs for later models. The purpose of the Stack is to identify where selection, compression, substitution, and loss of corrective contact occur.

3.1 Reality

Reality is the ground condition that the system is intended to perceive, explain, serve, or change. It contains more causal and contextual structure than any representation can preserve. Some relevant conditions may remain unmeasured, unclassified, or unknown. Reality cannot be captured in full. It nevertheless remains the reference against which representational alignment must be assessed.

3.2 Measurement

Measurement selects observable signals and records them in a stable form. This creates visibility, but it also determines what can enter the system. Conditions that cannot be registered by the available instruments do not cease to exist. They become operationally difficult to recognize. Measurement preserves selected observations while excluding context, tacit knowledge, timing, and conditions outside the instrument's range.

3.3 Metrics

Metrics aggregate measurements into standardized indicators. This allows comparison, ranking, evaluation, and coordination. The same process removes granularity, ambiguity, qualitative difference, and relations not contained in the aggregation rule. A metric can accurately calculate what it measures while failing to preserve the wider meaning of the condition it represents. Accuracy at one layer does not guarantee fidelity across the Stack.

3.4 Operational Representation

Measurements and metrics are organized into dashboards, models, classifications, interfaces, targets, forecasts, and other representations that can guide action. The operational representation provides a usable view of complexity. It can also conceal provenance, uncertainty, construction history, and the distinction between observed and inferred content. The system increasingly responds to the operational representation because it is more legible and actionable than the reality from which it was derived.

3.5 Optimization

Optimization begins when behavior is organized around the objectives encoded in the operational representation. Resources, incentives, and decisions increasingly flow toward what the system can record, compare, and reward, giving the represented objective practical authority. At that point, the representation is no longer merely describing performance. It is helping shape it. Participants adapt to the metric, target, model, or interface, and those adaptations can alter the underlying condition itself. What began as a way of representing reality starts to reorganize the reality it was meant to track.

3.6 Narrative

Narrative constructs meaning around the outputs of the system. It explains what happened, why it happened, and what should happen next. Narrative supports coordination by converting partial outputs into a communicable account. It can also close uncertainty prematurely. Contradiction, alternate causality, and the transformation history beneath the outputs disappear from view. A coherent explanation of represented performance becomes mistaken for evidence of real-world improvement.

3.7 The Central Substitution

At each layer, the system substitutes something easier to handle for something harder to grasp directly. A condition is reduced to a signal, then translated into a metric, incorporated into an operational model, and eventually optimized. Over time, those optimized outputs can begin shaping how the system explains what is happening.

The problem is not that any of these representations are false or imaginary. Metrics, models, and procedures are real objects with real effects. The problem begins when the distinction between the representation and the underlying condition starts to disappear. As that distinction weakens, the representation takes on more of the authority that once belonged to the reality it was meant to describe.

4. The Drift Principle

The Drift Principle describes why representational divergence tends to accumulate in scaled systems:

Representations can be compressed, optimized, distributed, and reused faster than real-world conditions can correct them.

Representations move easily through systems. They can be copied, summarized, ranked, reformatted, combined, and transmitted with comparatively little friction. Correction is slower. It may require observation, investigation, judgment, accountability, material consequence, or the reconstruction of context that earlier transformations removed.

As a system scales, it increases the speed and density of representational activity. More decisions depend on models, summaries, categories, and indicators. Representations become increasingly useful as infrastructure because they allow the system to coordinate across distance and complexity.

The same process increases the distance between operational decisions and the conditions those decisions affect. Compression is central to this process. Compression reduces complex conditions into representations that can be transmitted, compared, and acted upon. Each transformation preserves selected information while excluding context, ambiguity, and relations that have not been encoded.

Repeated transformation can make relevant distinctions increasingly difficult to recover. A summary may be accurate relative to the document it summarizes while the document is already derivative of an earlier representation. Later representations can preserve the apparent conclusion while losing access to the observations, uncertainty, and alternatives from which it emerged.

This is Recursive Compression. Already compressed representations are repeatedly summarized, transformed, and reused as new inputs. Context lost at an earlier stage cannot be restored merely by processing the derivative more fluently. As representational transformation accelerates, correction faces a growing speed disadvantage. The system can produce and circulate new representations faster than it can test them against the world. Reality Drift begins when that imbalance becomes structurally persistent.

5. Mechanisms of Corrective Contact Loss

The Representation Stack describes the architecture through which reality becomes measurable, represented, optimized, and interpreted. The following mechanisms describe how ordinary representational processes become self-reinforcing misalignment.

5.1 Filtering

Some signals enter operational view while others are excluded. Filtering is necessary because no system can process every available condition. Drift risk develops when excluded conditions lose the ability to influence decisions, even when they remain important in reality.

5.2 Compression

Selected signals are reduced into portable metrics, categories, summaries, or proxies. Compression allows scale. It also removes distinctions. Drift becomes more likely when the distinctions being removed are the same distinctions later required for correction.

5.3 Representation Substitution

The representation becomes the object the system actually responds to. The metric substitutes for the outcome. The record substitutes for the person. The benchmark substitutes for capability. The procedure substitutes for resolution. The model substitutes for the environment. The original referent remains rhetorically important while becoming operationally secondary.

5.4 Proxy Optimization

Behavior becomes organized around improving the representation, which may initially improve the underlying condition because the proxy still retains meaningful alignment with its purpose. Over time, however, continued optimization can change that relationship. Participants learn how to perform for the proxy, resources shift toward what the system can observe and reward, and unmeasured conditions receive less attention. An Optimization Trap emerges when improving the proxy no longer reliably improves the underlying condition, yet the proxy remains the system's dominant definition of success.

5.5 Constraint Weakening

Constraints are forces capable of limiting, interrupting, or correcting system behavior, including material consequences, professional judgment, direct observation, local knowledge, contradictory evidence, external validation, legal accountability, or the ability to stop a process. Constraint weakening begins when these forces remain present but lose operational authority, allowing them to be acknowledged without materially changing what the system does. When that loss becomes sustained, Constraint Collapse occurs: constraints continue to exist symbolically while losing the causal force needed to redirect the system.

5.6 Feedback Substitution

Internal indicators begin to substitute for correction from the underlying conditions. A system can look heavily monitored while most of its feedback is circulating inside the same representational environment. Dashboards are checked against other dashboards, compliance is confirmed through procedure, and models are judged by benchmarks built from related assumptions or data. Even institutional reporting can become self-referential when later reports rely on material drawn from the same upstream sources. The issue is that the feedback has lost enough independence that it can no longer reliably correct the system.

5.7 Coherence Stabilization

Outputs increasingly agree with one another because they share categories, assumptions, sources, or optimization pressures. This agreement can be mistaken for external validation. Internal coherence rises while contact with independent evidence declines. Coherence is not contact.

5.8 Recursive Compression

Representations are reused as inputs for later representations. A summary becomes a source. A model-generated interpretation becomes training material. A derivative report becomes evidence for another report. Each stage may appear reasonable in isolation while the chain as a whole becomes increasingly detached from direct observation.

5.9 Representational Inversion

The representation begins producing the conditions it claims to measure. Behavior adapts to the categories, metrics, models, and procedures governing the system. These adaptations alter reality. The altered reality is measured again and interpreted through the same representational logic. The original relationship was that the representation remained answerable to reality. The inverted relationship is that reality becomes increasingly answerable to the representation.

6. Feedback Without Corrective Authority

Reality Drift cannot be understood simply as the absence of feedback. Modern systems often produce enormous amounts of feedback. They collect data, conduct audits, review performance, document complaints, publish assessments, and monitor their own outputs. The problem is that feedback can exist without possessing corrective authority.

A feedback channel remains operational in a formal sense when information passes through it. It becomes corrective only when that information can revise the representation or interrupt the process responsible for the misalignment. This distinction explains why recognition alone does not restore correction.

Participants may know that a metric is incomplete. Leaders may acknowledge that a process is burdensome. Reviewers may recognize that a model has limitations. Employees may document that formal success does not correspond to real-world improvement. The system can absorb all of this recognition as additional information while continuing under the same operational representation.

In a drifting system, criticism can become another input without becoming a constraint. Recognition is recorded, summarized, assigned, classified, and incorporated into the system's account of itself. The existence of the review process then becomes evidence that correction is taking place.

Correction requires more than recognition. It requires the ability to alter the object through which the system encounters reality. A system has not been grounded merely because it contains human review. Grounding requires a feedback path capable of changing the representation, target, objective, or procedure that produced the decision.

7. Recursive Drift and Apparent Confirmation

Reality Drift becomes self-reinforcing when optimization changes the environment being observed.

The recursive sequence is:

Reality → Representation → Proxy → Optimization → Behavioral Adaptation → Altered Reality → Recapture → Apparent Confirmation

The system begins by representing a real condition. It then organizes behavior around the representation. People, institutions, and environments adapt to what the representation rewards or recognizes. Those adaptations change the condition being measured.

When the altered reality is captured again, the system may interpret the resulting observations as independent confirmation of the original representation. It no longer recognizes the extent to which its categories, incentives, and interventions helped produce the evidence now being used to validate them.

The system has manipulated the environment, forgotten that it manipulated it, and interpreted the environment's response as independent confirmation of its own model. This process can occur without deliberate coordination. Each participant may be responding rationally to the representations available at their position within the system.

Provenance loss intensifies the problem. Multiple reports, models, summaries, or decisions may appear to agree because they inherit the same upstream source or assumption. Once their common origin disappears, derivative agreement can be mistaken for independent verification. Five reports do not constitute five sources when all five descend from the same observation. As representations circulate, their origins become harder to reconstruct. Conclusions remain visible after their evidential histories have disappeared. Repetition then supplies the appearance of confirmation.

8. Semantic Fidelity and the Preservation of Meaning

Reality Drift concerns the relationship between a system's representations and the conditions they are meant to organize. Semantic Fidelity focuses more specifically on what survives as those conditions are translated, compressed, modeled, or otherwise transformed. A representation has high semantic fidelity when it preserves enough meaning, context, and relational structure to support reliable interpretation and appropriate action while remaining open to correction from the conditions it refers to.

Fidelity declines when important distinctions disappear during representation, even if the output still looks complete. Wording may survive while meaning is thinned out, or data may remain intact after the context needed to interpret it has been stripped away. Conclusions can also travel forward without the uncertainty, provenance, or alternatives that originally gave them meaning. The result is an asymmetry in which representations become cleaner, more standardized, and easier to use while losing some of the conditions necessary for sound judgment.

Synthetic Realness appears when that loss of grounding is masked by coherence. A model, narrative, interface, or institutional account can feel authoritative because its parts fit together smoothly, even after its connection to external conditions has weakened. Internal completeness begins to substitute for contact with reality, leaving the system with representations that feel increasingly real precisely because the missing context is no longer visible.

9. Relationship to Existing Concepts

Reality Drift connects several established concepts without replacing them.

Goodhart's Law describes what happens when measures become targets. Reality Drift concerns a broader process in which representations of many kinds begin to displace the realities they were created to represent while the system remains coherent enough to keep operating. Goodhart effects

can be one route into that process, but they are not the only one. Procedural, narrative, classificatory, model-based, and recursively mediated forms of substitution can produce similar drift without depending on a single formal metric.

Cybernetic theories emphasize feedback as a condition of regulation and adaptation. Reality Drift is concerned with what happens when feedback is still present but no longer has enough authority to revise the system. The important distinction is between information returning to the system and external conditions retaining the power to change it.

Goal displacement offers another related case, especially when organizations begin substituting procedures or secondary objectives for their original purposes. Reality Drift places that substitution within a wider representational architecture by asking how the substitute acquires authority, how internal feedback stabilizes it, and how the system continues operating after the original relationship has weakened.

Concept drift, data drift, and model drift usually describe changes that reduce the performance of computational systems. Reality Drift extends beyond performance degradation. A system may continue to perform well by its own measures, or even appear to improve, while the relationship between those measures and the intended reality deteriorates.

Specification gaming and reward hacking describe situations in which an optimizing agent satisfies a formal objective while violating its intended purpose. These cases fit within Reality Drift, but the framework does not require a single optimizing agent. Drift can also emerge through distributed adaptation across institutions, technologies, procedures, and participants.

The distinctive concern of Reality Drift is not isolated error. It is the process by which representational error becomes coherent, operational, recursive, and survivable.

10. Propositions and Diagnostic Implications

Reality Drift generates several propositions that can guide empirical investigation. Greater dependence on operational proxies should increase the likelihood of divergence between represented performance and ground outcomes unless independent correction expands with it. Systems with delayed, filtered, or nonbinding feedback should also be able to sustain misalignment longer than systems in which feedback can revise targets, categories, or procedures.

Agreement among representations should become a weaker indicator of external alignment when those representations share upstream sources, assumptions, or transformation histories. Likewise, reforms that add monitoring without restoring corrective authority may increase representational complexity without producing corresponding improvements in ground outcomes.

A further prediction concerns optimization itself. Once optimization begins altering the environment being measured, subsequent observations should increasingly reflect the effects of the representation rather than serve as independent confirmation of it. Systems that can continue reporting success while underlying conditions deteriorate should therefore be more vulnerable to persistent drift than systems in which ground-level deterioration directly interrupts operation.

These propositions suggest a compact diagnostic process:

1. What reality is the system supposed to remain answerable to?
2. Through what representation does the system encounter that reality?
3. Which proxy or operational object actually governs decisions?
4. What output is being optimized?
5. What relevant conditions are excluded from the representation?
6. What evidence could contradict the representation?
7. Can that evidence change the representation, objective, or procedure?
8. Can the system report success while the underlying condition deteriorates?

The eighth question is decisive. If a representation can report success while the condition it stands for deteriorates, the system is structurally capable of Reality Drift.

No single warning sign establishes the condition. The diagnosis becomes stronger when operational persistence, representational divergence, weakening correction, and internal coherence appear together.

11. Implications

11.1 Institutions

Reality Drift reframes some forms of institutional failure as representational failure. Institutions depend on records, categories, procedures, metrics, and models to coordinate activity at scale, but over time those representations can become the primary environment through which the institution evaluates itself. Reform efforts often deepen this problem by adding new reporting requirements, accountability procedures, and performance indicators without restoring contact with the conditions those systems were meant to track. The institution becomes increasingly legible to itself while gaining little additional capacity to be corrected by the reality it was created to serve.

11.2 Artificial Intelligence

Artificial intelligence accelerates the production, transformation, and reuse of representations across large representational environments. AI systems can summarize derivative material, combine inherited assumptions, generate plausible explanations, and stabilize patterns in ways that improve access, coordination, and analysis, but the same capabilities also allow representations to circulate farther from the conditions that originally grounded them. The central risk is therefore not limited to inaccurate output. It is the growing production of coherent material whose provenance, exclusions, and transformation history are difficult to recover. When AI-mediated representations become inputs for later models, reports, decisions, and cultural materials, Recursive Compression intensifies, making derivative agreement easier to produce and harder to distinguish from independent confirmation. Representational power can therefore scale faster than corrective contact, creating conditions in which Reality Drift becomes more persistent.

11.3 Human Cognition

Individuals operating inside low-fidelity representational environments inherit much of the interpretive work that the surrounding systems no longer perform reliably. When metrics, interfaces, institutional language, and automated outputs cannot be taken at face value, people must reconstruct context, compare competing representations, verify sources, and infer what the system is actually responding to. Filter Fatigue names the burden created by this transfer of verification and interpretation onto the individual. Cognitive effort remains high, yet additional effort produces diminishing gains in orientation because the surrounding representations no longer preserve enough of the distinctions needed for reliable judgment. Reality Drift does not by itself explain burnout, distraction, or psychological distress, but it identifies a structural condition that may increase the cognitive cost of maintaining orientation and that warrants separate empirical study.

11.4 Co-Drift Across Domains

Institutional, technological, and cognitive systems increasingly shape one another rather than drifting in isolation. Institutional representations influence what people notice and prioritize, while people adapt their behavior to the categories, metrics, and incentives those representations create. Artificial intelligence then processes the resulting records and produces additional representations that re-enter institutions, culture, and individual cognition as new inputs. Through this recursive exchange, the domains can begin reinforcing one another's assumptions and apparent coherence even as their shared contact with external conditions weakens. Co-drift describes this possibility that multiple systems can stabilize one another while drifting together.

12. Correction Architecture

Reality Drift cannot be eliminated entirely because representation is unavoidable. It can be limited by preserving pathways through which reality can revise the system.

12.1 Reality Recapture

The system returns to underlying conditions and gathers evidence that has not already been filtered through its dominant categories and assumptions. Reality recapture may involve direct observation, qualitative investigation, local knowledge, primary sources, counterexamples, or measures constructed outside the existing operational framework.

12.2 Proxy Revalidation

Metrics, models, categories, and procedures are tested against the reality they are supposed to represent. A proxy must be capable of losing authority when it stops tracking its intended condition. A system that cannot demote a failing proxy cannot reliably correct itself.

12.3 Constraint Restoration

Professional judgment, contradictory evidence, material limits, local knowledge, long-term outcomes, and lived experience are restored as forces capable of interrupting optimization. Constraint restoration requires more than consultation. The restored constraint must be able to change what the system does.

12.4 Feedback Reopening

Real-world outcomes are allowed to modify the system's categories, assumptions, objectives, and procedures. Feedback reopening occurs when the system can reconsider the representational structure through which it interprets feedback, rather than merely adjusting outputs within that structure.

12.5 Semantic Fidelity Preservation

Context, uncertainty, provenance, and relational structure are protected across summarization, classification, automation, and reuse. Compression is treated as a transformation with costs. Systems document what has been excluded and preserve routes back to less compressed forms.

12.6 Provenance Recovery

Claims and decisions are reconnected to their originating observations and evidence. The system distinguishes among direct observation, interpretation, summary, citation, and recursive reproduction. Apparent agreement is evaluated in light of shared sources and dependencies.

Correction does not require abandoning representation, abstraction, or optimization. It requires restoring the authority of reality over the representations used to organize it.

13. Conclusion

Reality Drift identifies a class of failures that ordinary error models often miss because the system does not have to stop working when correction weakens. Its representations may remain coherent, useful, and institutionally authoritative even as they lose contact with the conditions they were meant to track. Procedures continue, metrics improve, and explanations remain plausible while contradiction is absorbed without being allowed to revise the structure through which the system operates.

Representation makes scale possible, but it also creates distance from what is being represented. When transformation and reuse accelerate faster than correction, that distance can accumulate. If constraints lose authority, misalignment becomes survivable, and when optimization changes the environment being observed, the system may begin reading its own effects as independent confirmation.

The decisive question is therefore not whether the system still functions, but whether reality retains the authority to revise the representations through which it functions. Once that authority is lost, continued operation can become the mechanism by which misalignment survives. The absence of failure is not proof of alignment.

Conceptual Foundations

These works are presented as conceptual foundations and intellectual antecedents rather than as direct sources for each claim developed in this paper.

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